

From Forest Waste to a Future Full of Possibilities: The Journey of Manisha

People used to think that fallen pine needles were trash from the forest.. Manisha saw something else in them. She saw a chance to help people make a living to protect the forest and to show women that they can do things.

A Small Village, Big Dreams

There is a village called Ladwara in the Kangra district of Himachal Pradesh. It is surrounded by hills and forests full of pine trees. Every year a lot of pine needles fall on the ground. Most people think these needles are useless. In the summer they can even cause forest fires, which hurt the environment.

Manisha did not see the pine needles that way. She thought they could be used to make money for women to protect the forest and to make a difference in her community.

Manisha is thirty years old now. She is the leader of a group of fifteen women who make things from the pine needles that fall from the trees. What they do helps families earn money. It also shows that people can make a living if they use the things they have, around them in a clever way and work hard. The pine needles are a part of this. Manisha and the women are using the needles to create jobs and take care of the forest at the same time.



Manisha, founder of the women-led pine needle handicraft enterprise in Ladwara village.

Growing Up with Responsibility

Manisha was raised in a family where they had to think about every single expense. As the child she saw how hard her parents worked from a very young age. Her parents always told her and her siblings to study but they did not have a lot of money so it was tough to make all their dreams come true.

Manisha did not give up she thought that getting an education would be her way out.

She finished her Bachelor's degree and then she got a Master's degree, in Social Work from IGNOU she did this while she was working at the time. During this time Manisha worked with a group that helped young girls, women and their communities become better leaders.

Meeting women from villages made Manisha see life in a different way.

A lot of these women wanted to earn some money. They did not have any way to do so. Some of them wanted to help pay for their children's education and others just wanted to help out at home without having to ask their families for everything.

Hearing all these stories made Manisha understand that the biggest problem was not that these women were not talented. It was that they did not have any opportunities.

"If women are willing to work, why can't we create work within the village itself?"

That simple question became the beginning of a much bigger journey.



An Idea Born During Difficult Times

The COVID-19 pandemic affected every family. Jobs were not stable, incomes were going down and many families in areas had a hard time paying for their daily needs.

During this time Manisha saw that women were having a tough time. When she talked to them they kept saying the thing.

"If we could find a way to earn money in our village life would be better."

These conversations really stayed with Manisha. Around the time she found out about the South Asia Women Foundation Fellowship. This fellowship was looking for people with ideas that could make a positive difference in society. Even though she had never applied for something like this before she thought she would try it out.

Her idea was pretty simple.

Why not use needles to make products that are good for the environment and at the same time create jobs for women? The idea was accepted.

Getting the fellowship gave her the courage to stop planning and start taking action. It was the step, towards creating something that would change many lives, including her own life.

"Sometimes the best opportunities are hidden inside the problems we see every day"



The forests that inspired a sustainable livelihood initiative.

Learning Before Starting

Manisha realized that just having an idea was not going to be enough to build a successful business. So before she started she wanted to learn how to do things. She got trained by craftspeople who were already working with pine needles. It took her three months to understand how everything was made. From picking pine needles in the forests to cleaning them, processing them, weaving them and finishing the products.

After she finished her training she asked women in her village to join her. At first eight women came together to learn and work as a team. As they got more confident and experienced more women wanted to be a part of it. The group slowly grew into a 15-member group that helped each other. Now they make than 20 different things like baskets, trays boxes to keep food in, keychains, earrings and things to hold pens. All made from pine needles that fell down naturally.

This whole experience did not just teach the women a skill but it also helped them start a business that is good, for the environment. The women learned how to make things in a way that's traditional and also helps to protect the environment. The business is an example of how traditional craftsmanship and taking care of the environment can go together. Manisha and the women are happy to be working with needles to make so many useful things.

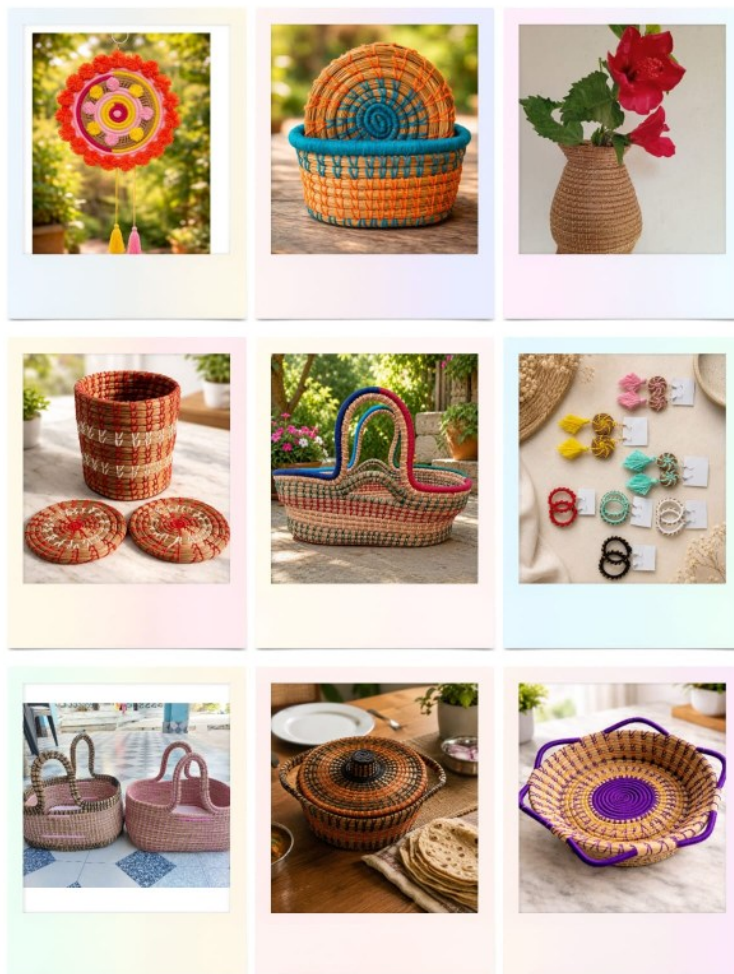


Expanding Beyond the Village

Starting the enterprise was the beginning. The tough part was finding people who would buy the things they made. Manisha and her team were great at making things. They did not know where to sell them or how to get more people to buy them.

Manisha did not wait for things to happen. She went out. Looked for ways to sell their things. She went to exhibitions and local stores that sell things. She also talked to organizations that help people who make things in areas. Manisha met people from these organizations. Showed them the things they made. She wanted to find people who would buy their things.

After some time their things were being sold in stores in Dharamshala and at exhibitions at NIFT Kangra. They also worked with organizations in Dehradun. This helped Manisha and her team get noticed and feel good, about the things they made. The team was very happy when they got their big orders. They had to make a lot of handmade pen stands and Rakhi collections. This showed them that the things they made were good enough to sell to people. Every time they completed an order they felt more confident. The women who made these things wanted to keep getting better at what they did. Manisha and her team kept making things and trying to improve their skills.



Eco-friendly handcrafted products made from naturally fallen pine needles.

Learning Through the IIT Delhi Training

Manisha's business was getting bigger and bigger. She found out that making products was just one part of running a successful business. Manisha also had to find the right people to sell her products to show her products in a way understand what people wanted to buy and keep her business organised.

The IIT Delhi Entrepreneurship Development Programme really helped Manisha with these things. This programme taught her to see her work as a business that could grow not something she was good at. She learned to plan understand the market and keep learning new things.

This programme was especially helpful for Manisha because she makes products from needles that have fallen on the ground. She can get these needles easily where she lives. As Manisha makes more products what she learned from the programme will help her think carefully about making new products selling them to people and making her business grow. Manisha will also think about how to show her products to people and what people want to buy. The IIT Delhi Entrepreneurship Development Programme was very useful, for Manisha and her business.

“सीखते रहने से ही काम आगे बढ़ता है। जब हमें नई चीज़ों के बारे में जानकारी मिलती है, तो हम अपने काम को और बेहतर तरीके से करने के बारे में सोच पाते हैं।”

The training also strengthened her confidence to think beyond the existing market for her products. Her enterprise has already moved beyond the village, with products reaching craft outlets in Dharamshala, exhibitions at NIFT Kangra, collaborations beyond the local area, and bulk orders. The exposure to entrepreneurship development has further encouraged her to view these opportunities as part of a larger business journey rather than isolated sales.





Taking Local Craft to Wider Markets

Manisha and her team have done a job over the years. They took an idea and turned it into a real business in a rural area. They went to exhibitions handicraft fairs and local markets to show people their products made from needles. This helped them reach people and get feedback from customers. They even got business opportunities from these events.

The team has become more confident as time went on. It started with a group of women but now it is a great example of how people can work together to make a better life. They use materials and traditional skills to make products that are good for the environment. The group is still. Trying to reach more people. They

want to make products and take care of the environment at the same time. They also want to help women become more independent financially.

Manisha thinks that every time they sell a product or talk to a customer they are one step closer to their goal. They want to build a sustainable business. They still have a lot of work to do. Manisha is hopeful. Every exhibition and every product sold brings them closer, to their dream of building a business. Manisha and her team are working hard to make this happen.

"This journey is not only about selling products—it is about creating opportunities, preserving nature, and inspiring more women to believe in their own potential."